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Control Your Living Costs

Why do you live where you live?

My uncle first taught me to think about that question. My uncle is a strong, skilled carpenter. He works fast and hard, and when he's finished a job it's done right. His buildings will be around decades after he's gone, and he's proud of that. My uncle is fairly quiet by nature. He'd rather listen than talk. But when he gets around to saying something, it's usually worthwhile to pay attention.

When we were small, living in Los Angeles, my uncle would tell us about a winter he spent in Ohio. He'd tell us about snow, how it turns to slush and then freezes. He'd tell us how he had to jump start his car when it was too cold for the starter to turn over. He'd put his hands in front of his mouth and breathe, explaining that to breathe properly in extreme cold you had to do it that way; otherwise your breath would freeze in your mouth and you'd never get it out. I'd be wide-eyed, straining to imagine what it would be like. It seemed a grisly horror story.

My uncle always finished the Ohio story the same way: "There I was, stuck in Cleveland for two months. I couldn't wait to leave. But everyone else was *choosing* to live there. They were living there *of their own free will*."